Brahmans,' moaned Badauni, 'collected another set of 1001 names of "his Majesty the Sun" and told the Emperor that he was an incarnation, like Ram, Krishna and other infidel kings; and though lord of the world, he had assumed his shape, in order to play with the people of our planet.'

For the orthodox at court these extraordinary changes would appear to be provocatively anti-Islam. The orthodox Sunni Shaikh Ahmad Sirhindi, who was most fond of repeating Prophet Muhammad's maxim that 'anything new which is introduced in my religion is condemnable', would have found the atmosphere distinctly unpalatable. Rafiuddin Shirazi, the Iranian visitor, claimed that '(Akbar) nursed a grievance against the Holy Prophet on account of his being the last of the prophets. Otherwise he could have claimed the position of a prophet for himself without facing opposition.' For Badauni, consigned to translating 'unimaginable nonsense', and unable to tolerate the tenor of the discussions at this plural, questioning court, there was no option but to retire even further from the warm glow of the Padshah's presence. On darbar days, he performed the kornish from a distance and took his place at the door, 'where the shoes are left', mourning for an uncomplicated dawn where the preferred and cherished children of God were good Muslims. For Abu'l Fazl, meanwhile, the non-Muslim peoples were simply 'other worshippers of God'.

*Jamal Bakhtyar, who appeared in court drunk and was sent home.